Guide: Becoming an English Spoken Word Artist

1. Build Your Foundation (Months 0-3)

Read widely, and listen even more.

- **Page poets:** Maya Angelou, Langston Hughes, Sylvia Plath, Walt Whitman, Mary Oliver, Ocean Vuong, Rupi Kaur, Warsan Shire.
- **Indian English poets:** Kamala Das, Nissim Ezekiel, Jayanta Mahapatra, Arun Kolatkar, Meena Alexander, Eunice de Souza, Tishani Doshi.
- **Spoken word voices:** Sarah Kay, Phil Kaye, Shane Koyczan, Taylor Mali, Anis Mojgani, Sabrina Benaim, Rudy Francisco, Neil Hilborn, Button Poetry, Def Poetry Jam.
- **Indian spoken word:** Aranya Johar, Harnidh Kaur, Abhijeet Chaudhary, Shamir Ahmed, Poojan Sahil.
- **Drama and prose:** Shakespeare, Tennessee Williams, Harold Pinter, Mahesh Dattani, Girish Karnad, Arundhati Roy.
- **Habit:** Watch one performance and read one poem a day aloud. Note what holds your attention: imagery, rhythm, pauses, or the ending.

2. Craft Your Writing (Ongoing)

- Write daily, even 10 minutes. Keep a notebook for overheard phrases, images, and feelings.
- Learn the toolkit: metaphor, imagery, anaphora, internal rhyme, alliteration, assonance, enjambment, and the volta (the turn).
- Know the forms: free verse, slam poem, sonnet, villanelle, ghazal in English, prose poem, and monologue.
- Spoken word is written for the ear. Use repetition, a strong first line, concrete images over abstractions, and an ending that lands.
- Find your themes (identity, family, language, class, love, loss, politics, mental health, migration) and write from specific personal detail.
- Edit by speaking: cut what trips the tongue, and mark breaths and pauses on the page.

3. Train Your Voice and Body

- **Voice:** Practice diaphragmatic breathing, vocal warm-ups, humming, and lip trills before performing.
- **Diction:** Work on clear consonants, pace control, and neutral but natural accent. Do not fake one.
- **Pacing:** Vary speed and volume deliberately. Silence is a tool.
- **Stage presence:** Take an acting, improv, or theatre workshop. Practice posture, eye contact, and minimal gestures.
- **Record yourself** and review pace, filler words, energy, and whether the audience would follow each line on a single hearing.

4. Start Performing (Months 3-6)

- Attend open mics in your city. Watch a few before signing up.
- Start with 2-3 minute pieces and memorize them so you can look at the audience.
- Join poetry circles, writing groups, college societies, and online communities (Discord, Reddit r/poetry, local WhatsApp groups).
- Ask a trusted peer for specific feedback after each performance: what landed, what lost them.
- Try a poetry slam to learn how to perform under time limits and scoring.

5. Build Your Online Presence

- **YouTube, Instagram Reels, TikTok-style short video:** Post 30-90 second clips with clean audio, and full performances on YouTube.
- Invest in a decent lavalier mic and good lighting. Audio quality matters more than video quality.
- Post the text as a caption or in a thread so it can be read and shared.
- Consistency (1-2 posts a week) beats perfection.
- Collaborate with musicians, animators, photographers, and other poets.
- Consider a newsletter or Substack for longer writing and event updates.

6. Platforms and Opportunities

- **Festivals:** Jaipur Literature Festival, Kerala Literature Festival, Tata Literature Live, Bangalore Poetry Festival, local college fests.
- **Collectives and venues:** Kommune, Spill Poetry, The Poetry Club, Storytellers' Club, Poetry Adda, open mic nights at cafes and bookshops.
- **International:** Button Poetry, Write About Now, Brave New Voices, and the Poetry Slam Inc. network.
- **Publishing:** Submit to journals (Muse India, The Bombay Literary Magazine, Indian Review, Poetry Magazine, The Rattling Wall) and consider a chapbook.
- **Competitions:** Slams, university contests, and online prizes with open submissions.

7. Sustain and Grow (Year 1+)

- **Mentorship:** Attend workshops by working poets, and approach artists you admire politely.
- **Develop a signature set:** 5-6 polished pieces of different moods: funny, tender, angry, reflective.
- **Income paths:** Paid gigs, workshops, school and corporate events, brand collaborations, audio content (Audible, Kuku FM), scriptwriting, lyrics, and teaching.
- **Protect your work:** Keep dated drafts, credit your pieces, and register or watermark published work when appropriate.
- **Handle feedback:** Take craft feedback seriously and ignore trolling.

8. Sample 6-Month Plan

Month	Focus
1	Daily reading and writing; study 5 spoken word performances
2	Write 8 pieces; start voice practice
3	Attend 3 open mics; perform one
4	Join a theatre or acting workshop; start posting clips
5	Perform monthly; collect feedback; try a slam
6	Build a 10-minute set; pitch to a festival or collective

Mindset Tips

- Expect stage fright. It fades with repetition.
- Don't chase virality at the cost of honesty.
- Your own accent, background, and mix of languages are assets. Bilingual writers can code-switch deliberately for effect.
- Be generous with other poets: share open mics, credit sources, and show up for others.